

Lovepreet Singh (+110kg) and Ajaya Babu (79kg) narrowly missed gold, while Bindyarani Devi (58kg) fell short of silver.

India did not field men in the 71kg, 88kg, 94kg and 110kg weight categories. The absence in these divisions stemmed from India's reduced quota following a series of anti-doping violations, with Dilbag Singh missing out in the 94kg category because of the quota cut.

Losing the gold by just one kilogram was particularly painful for Lovepreet. The Birmingham 2022 bronze medallist took charge of the contest after pre-event favourite Sanele Mao of Samoa failed all three snatch attempts at 175kg. Lovepreet capitalised by clearing 168kg, 173kg and a Games-record 176kg to open a 10kg lead heading into the clean and jerk.

But David Andrew Liti (New Zealand) produced a magnificent 223kg clean and jerk to overturn the deficit and snatch gold by the narrowest of margins. Lovepreet managed 212kg in the clean and jerk for a total of 388kg, one kilogram behind Liti's Games-record total of 389kg.

Meanwhile, it was a special moment for the 29-year-old Harjinder Kaur, who improved on the bronze medal she won at the previous Commonwealth Games by clinching silver in the women's 69kg competition. She had won bronze at Birmingham 2022 in the 71kg division.

Amid stiff competition, Harjinder never wilted under pressure, executing all six lifts successfully to finish with 227kg and claim silver behind Canada's Charlotte Simoneau, who lifted 240kg for gold.

Simoneau was the standout performer, setting a Games record in the snatch (108kg), a Commonwealth and Games record in the clean and jerk (132kg), and a Games record in the total (240kg).

When Harjinder walked into the mixed zone clutching 'Finnie', the Games mascot, with camera flashes lighting up the area, her smile reflected not only the joy of winning silver but also the sacrifices her parents had made to help her reach this stage. Harjinder credited her family for their unstinted support.

"My family played an important role. For me to do well in weightlifting, my parents focused on my diet, shoes and kits, sacrificing a lot of things in the process. It was a bit of a struggle as I used to help my father in farming in Mehas, Punjab," she said.

Ajaya missed gold in the men's 79kg category by one kilogram to Malaysia's Muhammad Erry Hidayat despite setting a



**Carrying forward a legacy:** Inspired by his father, 2010 Commonwealth Games bronze medallist Valluri Srinivasa Rao, Ajaya Babu made his Games debut in Glasgow and clinched a memorable silver in the men's 79kg event, missing gold by a whisker. GETTY IMAGES

#### India performance at Commonwealth Games

| Venue (Year)                                   | G                   | S   | B   | T   | Finish |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------|-----|-----|-----|--------|
| <b>Hamilton (1930)</b>                         | Did not participate |     |     |     |        |
| <b>London (1934)</b>                           | 0                   | 0   | 1   | 1   | 12th   |
| <b>Sydney (1938)</b>                           | 0                   | 0   | 0   | 0   | --     |
| <b>Auckland (1950)</b>                         | Did not participate |     |     |     |        |
| <b>Vancouver (1954)</b>                        | 0                   | 0   | 0   | 0   | --     |
| <b>Cardiff (1958)</b>                          | 2                   | 1   | 0   | 3   | 8th    |
| <b>Perth (1962)</b>                            | Did not participate |     |     |     |        |
| <b>Kingston (1966)</b>                         | 3                   | 4   | 3   | 10  | 6th    |
| <b>Edinburgh (1970)</b>                        | 5                   | 3   | 4   | 12  | 6th    |
| <b>Christchurch (1974)</b>                     | 4                   | 8   | 3   | 15  | 6th    |
| <b>Edmonton (1978)</b>                         | 5                   | 5   | 5   | 15  | 6th    |
| <b>Brisbane (1982)</b>                         | 5                   | 8   | 3   | 16  | 6th    |
| <b>Edinburgh (1986)</b>                        | Did not participate |     |     |     |        |
| <b>Auckland (1990)</b>                         | 13                  | 8   | 11  | 32  | 5th    |
| <b>Victoria (1994)</b>                         | 6                   | 11  | 7   | 24  | 6th    |
| <b>Kuala Lumpur (1998)</b>                     | 7                   | 10  | 8   | 25  | 7th    |
| <b>Manchester (2002)</b>                       | 30                  | 22  | 17  | 69  | 4th    |
| <b>Melbourne (2006)</b>                        | 22                  | 17  | 11  | 50  | 4th    |
| <b>New Delhi (2010)</b>                        | 38                  | 27  | 36  | 101 | 2nd    |
| <b>Glasgow (2014)</b>                          | 15                  | 30  | 19  | 64  | 5th    |
| <b>Gold Coast (2018)</b>                       | 26                  | 20  | 20  | 66  | 3rd    |
| <b>Birmingham (2022)</b>                       | 22                  | 16  | 23  | 61  | 4th    |
| <b>Glasgow (2026)</b>                          | 13                  | 17  | 9   | 39  | 4th    |
| <b>Overall (Total)</b>                         | 216                 | 207 | 180 | 603 |        |
| <b>G: Gold; S: Silver; B: Bronze; T: Total</b> |                     |     |     |     |        |